FIRST CUSTOMER

First Customer — 10 Days to Your First Paying Customers — Day 5: The Offer and Pricing for First Customers

Study guide · Self-study

10 Days to Your First Paying Customers · Day 5: The Offer and Pricing for First Customers

How to Use This Guide

This is your guide for Day 5, and you work through it alone. Write in it, argue with it, and put it down whenever you need to try something on a real prospect. The work is short but it is not passive: this guide works only if you write your own answers before you look at mine.

You have already done the hard part of the first four days. You named the specific person who pays, you found where they gather, you built an opener that earns attention with the First-Contact Standard (MEDJAY adaptation, based on Kahneman, Brehm and Guyer et al.), and you validated the problem with the Discovery Sequence. Today you turn that validated problem into something a customer can buy: a simple offer, framed around the progress the customer wants, and a price you can defend.

Read one section, then stop and write. When you reach What Would You Say?, write your response before you read the model answers at the back. The models are examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you, because they will be repeated to real people this week.

What you need: a notebook or a document, the notes from your Day 4 conversations, and about 90 focused minutes. Keep this guide open next to your notes on the real problems your prospects described.

- ☐ Read each section, then write your own version of it for your business before moving on.
- ☐ Keep your Day 4 notes in front of you: every offer decision today comes from a real problem a real person described.
- ☐ Complete the What Would You Say? exercises before reading Model Answers.
- ☐ Plan your Upskill Challenge now: which three real prospects will you show this offer to this week?

> **NOTES**
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> The most common mistake today is skipping straight to a price. A price is only meaningful next to a problem the customer has already told you matters. Start from their words, not from your cost sheet.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Here is what you will walk away with from this unit. Read the four lines once now and again at the end, and notice how far you moved.

- Knowledge: You will know why value-based pricing beats cost-plus for a first offer, and how Jobs to Be Done reframes your offer around the customer's desired progress rather than your features.
- Attitude: You will shift from "what should I charge for what I built?" to "what is the progress worth to the person who wants it?"
- Skill: You will be able to write a simple, one-sentence offer and set a defensible price with a stated reason behind the number.

- Upskill: You will be able to trade, don't concede: when a customer pushes on price, you will ask for something of equal value in return instead of discounting on instinct.

What a First Offer Actually Does

An offer is not your product. An offer is a promise of a result, at a price, delivered in a way the customer can say yes to. Your product might be software, a service, or a physical thing; the offer is the shape you put around it so a first customer can buy with confidence.

First customers buy differently from later ones. They are taking a risk on someone unproven, so their minds run a fast, quiet calculation: what do I get, how sure am I, and what happens if this goes wrong? The offer answers all three before they ask. Chris Voss and Tahl Raz describe how a guarded prospect is not persuaded by more features; they are moved by clarity and by feeling understood. Your offer should read like someone listened to the problem and wrote a specific solution to it.

Rob Fitzpatrick's rule from Day 1 applies here too: talk about their problem in their words, not your idea. If your Day 4 notes contain a sentence like "we lose a day every month reconciling these invoices by hand," your offer should echo that sentence back. The customer's own words are the raw material of a good offer.

Keep it narrow. A first offer that tries to cover every kind of customer becomes generic, and generic feels risky. One offer, one problem, one result. You will widen it after your first paying customers teach you what they actually bought.

- Write one sentence that names the problem in the customer's words.
- Write one sentence that names the result they get, and by when.
- List everything you will actually deliver to create that result.
- Cut anything the customer did not mention in discovery.

> **NOTES**
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> If your offer sentence would fit any customer in your market, it is too broad. Add the specific person and the specific problem.

Framing with Jobs to Be Done

Clayton Christensen's Jobs to Be Done asks a better question than "what does my customer want?" It asks: what progress is the customer trying to make, and what are they hiring me to do about it? People do not buy a drill; they buy a hole in the wall, and sometimes they buy the shelf that is already up. The job is the progress, not the product.

This matters because the same product serves different jobs for different people, and the price follows the job. Two customers might buy the same monthly reporting service. One hires it to stop being embarrassed in front of her board. The other hires it to win back two hours each week. Same product, different progress, different value.

To find the job, return to the past-behavior answers from your Day 4 discovery. What did they already try, what did it cost them in time or money, and what did they do instead when nothing worked? That last question is gold: their current workaround is your real competitor, and the workaround tells you what the job is worth to them today.

When the job is clear, your offer stops being a list of features and becomes a statement of progress. That is the frame a first customer can repeat to a colleague and approve.

- What was the customer doing before they looked for a solution?
- What did that workaround cost them, in hours, money or stress?
- What does the world look like one month after the job is done?
- Write the job in one sentence: "Help me get from (current state) to (desired state) so I can (why it matters)."
- Practice example: a B2C side-fencing installer frames his offer as "Help a homeowner with a growing dog get a safe yard this month so the dog can be outside without a lead," not "fence installation, various sizes."

> **NOTES**
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> Watch out: a feature your customer never mentioned is usually not the job. If it mattered, they would have described the outcome it creates.

Pricing for Value and Learning, Not Cost-Plus

Cost-plus pricing starts from your costs and adds a margin. It is comfortable because it feels fair, and it is dangerous for a first offer because your customer does not care what your costs are. They care what the result is worth to them. Cost-plus also caps you at whatever you happen to spend today, which is a poor measure of value.

Value-based pricing starts from the outcome. What does the problem cost the customer now, per month or per job? What is the result worth? Price as a fraction of that value, and say the reason out loud. This is not about charging the highest number you can say with a straight face. It is about connecting the number to something the customer already told you.

Tversky and Kahneman showed that an initial number anchors judgment, even when it is arbitrary: whoever names a number first pulls the conversation toward it. Use this honestly. Anchor on real, checkable value such as the customer's own stated cost of the problem, never on a figure you invented to sound impressive. Invented anchors are manipulation and customers eventually smell them.

A first price serves two goals: win the customer and buy learning. Sometimes you deliberately price low to learn fast, and you say so to yourself: this is a learning price, and I will raise it after the first three customers. That is different from cost-plus, because you chose the number on purpose. Write down which goal the number serves. If you do check current market prices or a competitor's quote before you quote, treat anything you plan to repeat to a customer as something to verify, not memorize.

There is also a strong case for one simple price and one clear reason, rather than a menu. Iyengar and Lepper found that a wider spread of options can overwhelm rather than help: beyond a point, more choices slow decisions and increase doubt. For a first offer, fewer options win.

> **NOTES**
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> A common mistake: quoting a number and then immediately discounting before the customer has said anything. That teaches the customer your first number was not real.
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> - Write the customer's current cost of the problem per month, using their own numbers from discovery.
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> - Write the value of the result in the same units: hours saved, revenue gained, risk avoided.
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> - Set your price as a stated fraction of that value, and write the sentence you will say: "This costs you about (their cost) a month, so we charge (your price) because (the reason)."
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> - Decide the goal of this price: winning a first customer, buying learning, or full value. Write it down.
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> - Practice example: a B2B bookkeeping service for small restaurants learns a customer spends 12 hours a month on invoices at an internal cost the customer estimates at 480 per month, then prices the first three months at 150 per month and says plainly: "I am keeping my first customers close so I can learn your workflow; the price after that will reflect the value."
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> - Practice example: a B2C personal-training offer prices a six-week starter block at a figure the customer compares with two months of unused gym membership, and names that comparison out loud.

Keep the Offer Simple and the Options Real

A simple offer has three parts: the result, the boundary, and the next step. The result is what the customer gets. The boundary says what is included and what is not, which protects you from scope creep and protects the customer from surprises. The next step is one small action: a short call, a paid trial, a deposit. You will build the next step out fully on Days 6 and 7; today, just name it.

You may be tempted to build three tiers to look established. Do not build tiers to steer people. If you genuinely offer a smaller scope, a standard scope and a larger scope, present them with honest Good-Better-Best logic, and make sure each one is real: each tier must be something you would happily deliver, not a decoy invented to push people to the middle. Understanding why customers drift to the middle option is useful psychology; creating a fake option to trap them is not.

Likewise, scarcity works only when it is true. If you have capacity for three customers this month, saying so is honest and customers respond to it because real limits signal real demand. An invented deadline destroys trust the moment it resets.

Finish the offer with a plain boundary sentence. Customers read clarity as competence.

- Result: what the customer gets, in one sentence.
- Boundary: what is included, what is not, and for how long.
- Next step: the one small action you will ask for.
- Check every option and every limit: is it real? If not, remove it.

- Practice example: a B2B design service offers one package, two revisions, delivery in ten working days, and a paid two-week trial; the founder can genuinely take three trial customers this month and says so.

> **NOTES**
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> If you cannot explain an option in one sentence, your customer cannot either. Cut it or split it.

Trading Instead of Discounting

When a customer pushes on price, your instinct will be to give something up to keep the deal alive. Resist it once, deliberately. Instead of conceding, ask for something of equal value in return: a faster decision, a longer commitment, a smaller scope, a testimonial, a referral, a case study, a deposit up front. The rule is simple and it applies to every conversation: concessions are traded, never given.

Why does this work psychologically? First, people value what they work for. Robert Cialdini's commitment and consistency research shows that a customer who has invested effort in an agreement is far more likely to follow through on it. Second, a trade reframes the conversation from "is your price fair?" to "what do we both need here?", which is a far better question. Third, it protects your price for every customer after this one.

This is a negotiation rule, separate from objection handling. You will learn the objection conversation in full on Day 8. For now, the sentence to rehearse is simple: "I can do that if you can do this." Say it calmly, without apology. Then wait.

> **NOTES**
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> Only offer a trade you actually want. A trade you resent will show up later as poor service.
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> - Script the trade: "I can move on the price if you can (commit for six months / pay the first month up front / give me a testimonial when we finish / reduce the scope by one part)."
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> - Write two things you would genuinely accept in return for a lower price.
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> - Practice example: a B2C photography package is quoted at a figure; the customer asks for less. The photographer offers to remove the second location from the shoot in exchange, keeping the price for the main session.
>
> - Practice example: a B2B software founder is asked for a discount; he offers ten percent off in exchange for a twelve-month commitment paid quarterly, and the customer accepts.

Apply It in Your Role

You are the founder, so there is no one to approve your offer and no pricing committee. That freedom is an advantage: you can test fast. But it also means you must be your own check. Build the offer, say it out loud to three real prospects this week, and change it based on what they do, not what they say.

Do this today, in order:

1. Write the job and the offer sentence for your primary customer, in their words from Day 4.

2. Set a price with a stated reason, and write down what goal that price serves.

3. Write the boundary: what is included and what is not.

4. Write two trades you would genuinely accept.

5. Say the whole offer out loud three times. Cut any word you stumble on.

Then take it to the real world. Show it to the prospects who spoke to you on Day 4. Watch which part they react to. If they ask a question you did not expect, that is your offer telling you it is unclear. Fix the sentence, not the person.

Notice the feelings this brings up. Most founders feel a spike of discomfort when they say a price out loud for the first time. That discomfort is normal and it fades with repetition. Do not mistake it for evidence your price is wrong.

☐ Write your offer sentence, price and reason, boundary, and two trades.

☐ Say it out loud three times and cut what you stumble on.

☐ Show it to three real prospects from your Day 4 conversations this week.

☐ Write down the exact question each prospect asked; that question is your next edit.

> **NOTES**
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> A common mistake: changing the price after every single reaction. Change the offer's clarity first; change the number only when you see a pattern.

What Would You Say?

Write your own answer to each situation before reading Model Answers. Your wording will differ from mine, and that is correct. What matters is the principle: name the result, state the price with a reason, and offer a trade rather than a concession.

- A prospect you spoke with on Day 4 says: "So what would this actually cost me?" Write your answer, including the reason behind the number.
- A B2C customer says: "That feels expensive compared with what I have seen." Write what you say, without discounting yet.
- A B2B prospect says: "We like it, but we need ten percent off." Write your trade response.
- A prospect asks whether you can do more than the offer includes. Write your boundary answer.
- A customer asks: "Why should I buy from someone with no track record?" Write a short, honest answer that names the risk reversal you are willing to offer.

> **NOTES**
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> Do not aim for a script that sounds smooth. Aim for a sentence you could say to a real person without flinching.

Key Takeaways

Here is the whole day in a short list. If you remember nothing else, remember the first three lines.

- An offer is a promise of a result at a price, not a description of your product.
- Frame the offer around the progress the customer wants, using Jobs to Be Done.
- Price from the value of the result and the learning you want, never from cost-plus alone.
- Anchor on real, checkable value, and state the reason behind the number.
- Keep the offer simple: result, boundary, next step.
- Every option and every limit must be real; no invented scarcity, no fake tiers.
- When pushed on price, trade, don't concede: "I can do that if you can do this."

Quiz

Answer all five questions, then check the answer key at the end of this guide. Choose one option per question.

1. Why is cost-plus pricing a weak starting point for a first offer?

   A. It is always illegal to price below cost
   B. The customer cares about the value of the result, not your costs
   C. It takes too long to calculate
   D. It always produces the highest possible price

2. What does Jobs to Be Done ask you to focus on?

   A. The features your product has
   B. The progress the customer is trying to make
   C. The price your competitors charge
   D. The number of customers in your market

3. A customer says your price is too high, and you immediately offer a discount before they say anything more. What is the main problem?

   A. You have taught the customer your first number was not real
   B. You have broken a law
   C. You will lose the customer
   D. Nothing, this is standard practice

4. You want to lower your price for a customer. Which response fits the principle of trade, don't concede?

   A. Give the discount quietly and hope they refer someone
   B. Say no and end the conversation
   C. Ask for something of equal value in return, such as a longer commitment or a testimonial
   D. Offer a fake deadline to hurry the decision

5. When is it acceptable to use scarcity in a first offer?

   A. Whenever it helps close the deal

   B. Only when the limit or deadline is real

   C. Never, under any circumstances

   D. Only for B2B customers

Upskill Challenge

This is your on-the-job practice for the next 48 hours. Do it in your own business, with your own prospects, and write down what actually happened.

Part one. Write your offer on one page: the job in the customer's words, the result, the price and the reason behind it, the boundary, and two trades. Read it aloud until it sounds like you.

Part two. Show that page to three real prospects from your Day 4 conversations. Present it as an offer, not a survey question. Then stay quiet and let them react. Write down, word for word, the first question each one asks.

Part three. If any of them pushes on price, practice the trade sentence out loud: "I can do that if you can do this." Note whether they accepted, negotiated, or walked away, and what you learned about your number.

Bring all of it back on Day 6, when you will turn this offer into a paid pilot or a launch deal for your founding customers.

- Offer page written, with the job, result, price, reason, boundary and two trades.
- Three real prospects shown the offer.
- The first question each prospect asked, recorded word for word.
- Any price pushback answered with a trade, and the outcome noted.
- One sentence on what you will change in the offer, and why.

> **NOTES**
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> Log the reaction, not the compliment. "Sounds interesting" tells you little; "does that include the second site?" tells you exactly what to fix.

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. Your words will differ, and your principle should not. Each model is followed by why it works.

- 1. "Good question. You told me you spend about six hours a month on this and it has been costing you roughly (their figure) in lost time. The setup is (your price) once, then (your price) a month, because that gets the hours back from the first week. Would it help if I walked you through exactly what happens in week one?"

- Why it works: it anchors on the customer's own cost, not an invented number, and it earns the price with a reason.
- 2. "That is fair to raise. The price is built around the result you described, not around a comparison with a smaller version of it. If we compare it with the cost of the problem staying as it is, the difference is (their figure) a month. Shall I show you what the first month looks like?"
- Why it works: it acknowledges the feeling without defending features and moves the comparison to a criterion the customer already gave you.
- 3. "I can look at that. If we go to that figure, I would ask for a twelve-month commitment paid quarterly, and a short testimonial when we finish. Does that work for you?"
- Why it works: trade, don't concede. The customer invests, and the price holds for everyone else.
- 4. "What you see here is the full first offer, and it is deliberately narrow so the first few customers get a great result. If you need more, we can scope it as a separate piece and I will price it honestly. Which part were you thinking about?"
- Why it works: the boundary is clear, the door is open, and nothing is promised that does not exist.
- 5. "You are right that I am new to this. That is exactly why I am keeping the first few customers close and offering a short paid trial, so you are not betting a year on me before you have seen the work. If the trial does not deliver what we agreed, we stop there."
- Why it works: it is honest about risk and offers a real risk reversal rather than a claim. The full pilot structure comes on Day 6.
- Quiz answers:
- 1. B. The customer's decision rests on what the result is worth to them, so start from value and use cost only as a floor.
- 2. B. Jobs to Be Done frames the offer around the progress the customer wants, and the price follows that progress.
- 3. A. Discounting before a customer responds signals your first number was soft and invites more pressure.
- 4. C. Trade, don't concede: ask for equal value, so the customer invests and the price holds for everyone.
- 5. B. Scarcity works only when the limit is real; invented deadlines destroy trust when they reset.

> **NOTES**
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> Your answer does not need to be as long as mine. Shorter is usually better. What it must have is the same skeleton: result, reason, next step.

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